

DEVGUARD

Employee Handbook & HR Policy Document

Version 3.0 · Effective Date: June 1, 2025

Issued by: Human Resources Department

Document Classification: Internal — All Employees

This handbook constitutes a binding agreement between DevGuard and its employees. Every employee is required to read, understand, and acknowledge receipt of this document upon joining and upon each annual revision.

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SECTION 1

Document Control & Welcome

1.1 Introduction & Company Values

Welcome to **DevGuard**. Founded on the principles of integrity, innovation, and inclusivity, DevGuard is a diversified technology and engineering enterprise committed to delivering world-class solutions to its clients while fostering a workplace where every individual can thrive. We believe that our people are our most valuable asset, and this handbook exists to ensure every employee has the clarity, support, and protection they deserve.

Our Core Values

- **Integrity:** We act honestly and transparently in every interaction — with colleagues, clients, and partners.
- **Innovation:** We encourage bold ideas, calculated risk-taking, and continuous improvement.
- **Inclusion:** We celebrate diversity and ensure every voice is heard and respected, regardless of background.
- **Accountability:** We own our commitments, deliver on our promises, and learn from our mistakes.
- **Excellence:** We set and pursue the highest standards in everything we undertake.

Mission Statement

DevGuard' mission is to **engineer a better tomorrow** — by delivering sustainable technology solutions, empowering our employees to grow, and creating lasting value for all our stakeholders.

1.2 Legal Status of This Handbook

This Employee Handbook and HR Policy Document (**'the Handbook'**) constitutes a **legally binding agreement** between DevGuard (hereinafter 'the Company') and each employee. Acceptance of employment with DevGuard implies unconditional acceptance of all policies herein. A signed acknowledgement of receipt is required from every employee within **5 working days** of their joining date and upon receipt of any updated version.

Where any provision of this Handbook conflicts with applicable national or state/union territory legislation, the applicable law shall prevail. However, where this Handbook provides **greater benefits** than the statutory minimum, the Handbook provisions shall apply.

1.3 Document Control Information

Document Title	DevGuard Employee Handbook & HR Policy Document
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Version	3.0
Effective Date	June 1, 2025
Review Frequency	Annual (every June 1) or upon significant legislative change
Document Owner	Chief Human Resources Officer (CHRO), DevGuard
Approved By	Board of Directors, DevGuard
Classification	Internal — Mandatory reading for all employees
Supersedes	Version 2.1 dated March 15, 2023

SECTION 2

Leave and Attendance Policy

2.1 Standard Working Hours & Attendance Tracking

2.1.1 Standard Work Schedule

DevGuard operates on a **5-day work week (Monday to Friday)**. The standard working day is **9 hours**, inclusive of a **1-hour unpaid lunch break**, resulting in **8 productive billable hours** per day.

Morning Shift	8:00 AM – 5:00 PM (standard)
General Shift	9:30 AM – 6:30 PM (alternative, role-dependent)
Core Hours	10:00 AM – 4:00 PM (mandatory presence for all employees)
Flexible Window	Employees may start between 8:00 AM and 10:30 AM, subject to manager approval
Overtime Policy	Any work beyond 9 hours requires prior written manager approval; compensatory off is granted at 1:1 ratio for non-managerial roles

2.1.2 Attendance Tracking

All employees are required to mark attendance using the **Company's HRMS portal (Apex HRM)** or the **biometric device** at their respective office location. Remote employees must log attendance via Apex HRM by **10:30 AM** on each working day.

- Late arrival after **10:30 AM without prior notice** will be marked as Half-Day Leave.
- Absence without marking attendance and without prior approval will be treated as **Loss of Pay (LOP)**.
- Three or more consecutive LOP days without communication to HR will trigger a formal **Abandonment of Employment** notice.
- Monthly attendance reports are generated by HR on the **1st of each month** and shared with department heads.

2.2 Casual Leave (CL)

Annual Allocation	12 days per calendar year (January 1 – December 31)
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Accrual	1 day per completed calendar month ; new joiners accrue from the month of joining
Maximum at one time	3 consecutive CL days ; more than 3 consecutive days requires EL or LOP
Advance Notice	Minimum 1 working day prior notice required (same-day CL requires manager's real-time approval)
Application Method	Via Apex HRM portal under Leave Management > Apply Casual Leave
Carry-Forward	Not permitted. Unused CL lapses on December 31 each year
Encashment	Not eligible for encashment
Half-Day CL	Available; deducted as 0.5 days from the CL balance
Public Holidays	CL sandwiched between two public holidays (Friday + Monday) counts as CL for each day absent

Note to Employees: Casual Leave is intended for personal errands, family obligations, or short-notice needs. It is not a substitute for sick leave or earned leave and must not be applied retroactively, except in genuine emergencies with HR notification within 24 hours.

2.3 Sick Leave (SL)

Annual Allocation	12 days per calendar year
Accrual	1 day per completed calendar month
Advance Notice	Not required for genuine illness; employee must notify their manager and HR via Apex HRM by 10:00 AM on the first day of absence
Medical Certificate	Mandatory for any SL exceeding 2 consecutive days ; a registered medical practitioner's certificate must be submitted within 2 days of returning to work
Carry-Forward	Up to 6 unused SL days may be carried forward to the next calendar year; maximum accumulated SL at any time is 24 days

Encashment at Exit	Unused SL up to 30 days is encashable upon retirement or resignation with more than 5 years of service; calculated on Basic Salary
Absence of Certificate	SL without a medical certificate (for absence > 2 days) will be converted to LOP

2.4 Paid Time Off / Earned Leave (EL)

Annual Allocation	18 days per calendar year for employees who have completed 1 year of continuous service
Eligibility	Employees must complete 240 working days in a year to earn the full 18 EL days; prorated for employees with fewer days worked
Accrual	1.5 days per completed calendar month
Minimum Duration	Minimum 3 consecutive days per EL application
Advance Notice	Minimum 15 calendar days prior notice required; applications within 15 days will be approved only in exceptional circumstances
Application Method	Via Apex HRM portal under Leave Management > Apply Earned Leave; must include travel dates if applicable
Approval Hierarchy	1st: Immediate Manager approval (within 3 days) → 2nd: HR review (within 2 days) → Final: HR marks approved in system
Rejection Policy	If EL is rejected, the written reason must be provided within 3 working days; employee may escalate to CHRO if rejected twice
Carry-Forward	Up to 30 EL days may be carried forward; balances exceeding 30 days at year-end will be automatically encashed in the January salary
Encashment on Resignation	Remaining EL balance (up to a maximum of 45 days) is encashed in the F&F Settlement at Basic Salary rate

2.5 Parental Leave

2.5.1 Maternity Leave

Duration	26 weeks (182 calendar days) for the first two children; 12 weeks for the third child and beyond
Eligibility	Female employees who have worked with DevGuard for at least 80 days in the 12 months preceding the expected delivery date
Pay During Leave	Fully paid at last drawn gross salary for the entire duration
Adoption	Commissioning mothers and adoptive mothers who adopt a child below 3 months of age are entitled to 12 weeks of paid maternity leave
Miscarriage / Medical Termination	6 weeks of paid leave immediately following the event, upon submission of medical documentation
Notice	Employee must notify HR in writing at least 8 weeks before the expected leave commencement date
Work from Home Post-Leave	Upon return, eligible for a 3-month hybrid arrangement with 2 days from home per week, subject to role requirements

2.5.2 Paternity Leave

Duration	10 working days
Eligibility	All male employees on confirmation (post-probation); applicable for the birth or legal adoption of a child
Pay During Leave	Fully paid at last drawn gross salary
Timing	Must be availed within 3 months of the child's birth or adoption date
Application	Apply via Apex HRM with supporting documentation (birth certificate / hospital letter) within 30 days of the event

2.6 Other Leave Types

Bereavement Leave	5 working days for immediate family (spouse, parent, child, sibling); 2 working days for extended family (grandparent, in-laws); fully paid; death certificate required within 10 days
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Marriage Leave	5 working days (once in employment tenure); fully paid; apply minimum 15 days in advance
Compensatory Off (Comp Off)	Granted when an employee works on a declared Company holiday or weekend at manager's written request; must be availed within 60 days of earning; non-transferable; non-encashable
Public Holidays	DevGuard observes 12 national and state-mandated public holidays per year; the annual holiday list is published by HR in December for the following year
Study / Examination Leave	Up to 5 days unpaid leave per academic year for approved professional certifications relevant to the employee's role; apply 21 days in advance with supporting documentation

2.7 Loss of Pay (LOP)

Loss of Pay (LOP) is the deduction of salary for days an employee is absent from work without any applicable paid leave balance or without approved leave. LOP is not disciplinary in nature unless it arises from repeated, unapproved absence.

Conditions Under Which LOP is Applied

- The employee has **exhausted all applicable paid leave balances** (CL, SL, EL) and still requires time off.
- The employee is absent **without prior approval** and without notifying their manager or HR within **24 hours** of the first absent day.
- SL is taken for **more than 2 consecutive days** without submission of a medical certificate.
- EL is applied for fewer than 3 days (minimum EL usage) and no CL or SL balance exists.
- The employee is **absent during a notice period** and the absence is not covered by an approved leave type.
- Habitual late arrival (more than **3 instances per month**) may result in half-day LOP per instance after a formal warning.

LOP Calculation

LOP is deducted from the **gross monthly salary** on a per-day basis. The daily rate is calculated as: **Gross Monthly Salary ÷ 26 working days**. LOP appears as a line-item deduction on the employee's monthly payslip. Employees can view their LOP record in real-time via the Apex HRM portal.

LOP does not affect an employee's service continuity for statutory benefits (e.g., Provident Fund contributions) unless the total LOP in a month exceeds 10 working days, in which case that month is treated as a break for gratuity calculation purposes.

■ CHATBOT QUICK-REFERENCE Q&A

Q: How do I apply for Casual Leave?

A: Log in to the Apex HRM portal (hrm.devguard.com), navigate to Leave Management > Apply Leave, select 'Casual Leave' as the leave type, choose your dates, add a reason, and submit. You must apply at least 1 working day in advance. Your manager will receive an automatic approval notification and must approve within 24 hours. You will receive a confirmation email once approved.

Q: What happens if I take sick leave for more than 2 days without a doctor's note?

A: If you are absent for more than 2 consecutive days under Sick Leave but do not submit a medical certificate from a registered medical practitioner within 2 working days of your return, those days will be automatically converted from SL to Loss of Pay (LOP). The deduction will appear on your next monthly payslip. To avoid this, please upload your medical certificate via Apex HRM > Leave Management > Upload Document within the required window.

Q: How many Earned Leave days can I carry forward to next year?

A: You may carry forward a maximum of 30 Earned Leave (EL) days. Any EL balance exceeding 30 days at the close of December 31 will be automatically encashed and credited to your January salary at your Basic Salary daily rate.

Q: Can I take Casual Leave and then extend it as Earned Leave?

A: Yes, you can combine CL and EL, but the combination must be planned and applied for in advance. If you begin a CL and decide to extend, you must apply for EL in the Apex HRM portal before your CL ends and get manager approval. You cannot retroactively apply EL for days already marked as LOP. Note: CL allows a maximum of 3 consecutive days; for longer periods, EL must be the primary leave type.

Q: What is the notice period for applying for Earned Leave?

A: You must submit your Earned Leave application at least 15 calendar days before your intended leave start date. Applications submitted with fewer than 15 days' notice will be approved only under exceptional circumstances at the manager's and HR's discretion, and the written reason for late application must be provided.

Q: I worked on a Sunday because my manager asked me to. How do I claim Comp Off?

A: Ask your manager to raise a Compensatory Off request in Apex HRM under Leave Management > Compensatory Off on the same day or the next working day. Once your manager submits the request, HR will approve and add the comp-off to your leave balance within 2 working days. You must avail this comp-off within 60 calendar days; after that, it expires and cannot be encashed.

Q: Does Maternity Leave affect my annual performance review?

A: No. An employee on approved Maternity Leave is deemed to have been at work for all purposes of performance evaluation, increment eligibility, and continuity of service. Your appraisal period will be assessed on the basis of work done prior to your leave, and no adverse inference will be drawn from the leave period.

SECTION 3

Code of Conduct & Workplace Policies

3.1 Core Behavioural Standards

Every employee of DevGuard is a representative of the Company's values. The following standards of conduct are mandatory and non-negotiable for all employees, contractors, interns, and third-party staff operating within DevGuard' premises or on behalf of the Company.

- **Professionalism:** Treat all colleagues, clients, vendors, and visitors with courtesy and respect at all times.
- **Honesty:** Do not misrepresent facts, falsify records, or provide inaccurate information in any official capacity.
- **Conflict of Interest:** Disclose any personal interest (financial, familial, or otherwise) that may conflict with your responsibilities at DevGuard to HR in writing within 5 working days of becoming aware of it.
- **Gifts and Hospitality:** Employees may not accept gifts valued above **INR 2,000** from vendors, clients, or business partners without written HR approval.
- **Social Media:** Employees must not post content that could disparage DevGuard, its clients, or colleagues. Company-specific information must never be shared on personal social media platforms.
- **Dress Code:** Business casual attire is expected in the office on all working days; formal attire on client visit days and board meeting days.

3.2 Anti-Harassment & POSH Policy

3.2.1 Zero-Tolerance Policy

DevGuard maintains an **absolute zero-tolerance policy** towards any form of harassment — including sexual harassment, workplace bullying, discrimination based on gender, caste, religion, race, disability, sexual orientation, or any other protected characteristic. This policy applies to all company premises, client sites, virtual workplaces, and company-sponsored events.

3.2.2 POSH (Prevention of Sexual Harassment) — As per the Sexual Harassment of Women at Workplace Act, 2013

In compliance with the **Sexual Harassment of Women at Workplace (Prevention, Prohibition and Redressal) Act, 2013** (POSH Act), DevGuard has constituted an **Internal Committee (IC)** to receive and adjudicate complaints of sexual harassment.

IC Composition	Presiding Officer (senior female employee), 2 Internal Members, 1 External Expert
IC Chairperson Email	ic.chairperson@devguard.com (confidential inbox)

Definition of SH	Includes unwelcome physical contact, sexually coloured remarks, showing pornography, requests for sexual favours, or any other unwelcome physical, verbal, or non-verbal conduct of a sexual nature
Complaint Timeline	A complaint must be filed within 3 months of the incident (extendable by 3 more months if the IC is satisfied with reasons for delay)
Inquiry Timeline	The IC must complete its inquiry within 60 days of receiving the complaint
Confidentiality	Names of complainant, respondent, and witnesses are strictly confidential; any breach of confidentiality by any party will be treated as misconduct
Interim Relief	The IC may recommend interim measures such as transfer of the respondent or leave to the complainant during the inquiry period
False Complaints	Malicious or false complaints made with intent to harm will be treated as misconduct and subject to disciplinary action

3.2.3 How to File a POSH Complaint

- **Step 1:** Write a complaint addressed to the IC Chairperson with a factual account of the incident(s), date(s), and witnesses (if any).
- **Step 2:** Submit the complaint via (a) the confidential email ic.chairperson@devguard.com, or (b) in a sealed envelope marked 'Confidential — IC Complaint' to any IC member.
- **Step 3:** The IC will acknowledge receipt within **3 working days**.
- **Step 4:** A conciliation process may be initiated if requested by the complainant (no monetary settlement is permissible at conciliation stage).
- **Step 5:** If conciliation fails, a full formal inquiry will be conducted with both parties heard.
- **Step 6:** The IC will submit its findings and recommendations to the management within **60 days**.
- **Step 7:** Management will implement the recommended action within **60 days** of receiving the IC report.

3.3 Remote Work / Hybrid Work Policy

3.3.1 Eligibility and Approval

Employees are eligible for hybrid or fully remote work arrangements after completing **3 months of probation** and upon receiving written approval from their manager and HR. Remote work is a privilege, not an entitlement, and may be withdrawn if performance or connectivity standards are not maintained.

Hybrid Model (Standard)	3 days in-office + 2 days remote per week, with in-office days determined by the team manager
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Fully Remote	Permitted only for specific roles pre-designated as 'Remote-First' in the offer letter
Core Online Hours	10:00 AM – 4:00 PM IST , Monday to Friday (employees must be reachable on all company communication channels during core hours)
Response Time SLA	Employees must respond to messages/calls within 30 minutes during core hours; non-responsiveness without prior notice is treated as absent
Attendance Marking	Remote employees must mark attendance on Apex HRM by 10:30 AM ; failure to do so results in a half-day LOP
Workspace Requirement	Employees must have a dedicated, private workspace with stable internet (minimum 20 Mbps upload/download)

3.3.2 Equipment & Internet Reimbursement

Internet Allowance	INR 1,200 per month for all approved remote/hybrid employees, reimbursed upon submission of monthly bill
Equipment Policy	DevGuard provides a company-owned laptop and required peripherals; no personal devices may be used for company work without a signed BYOD agreement
Equipment Damage	Accidental damage is reported to IT within 24 hours; negligent damage will result in a proportional cost recovery from the employee
Home Office Setup	A one-time INR 5,000 home office allowance is available for employees on permanent remote contracts, claimed within 90 days of joining

3.3.3 Remote Work Do's and Don'ts

Do:

- Ensure video camera is on for all team and client video calls unless network conditions prevent it.
- Maintain the same level of professional communication (email, Slack) as if in-office.
- Complete and submit all daily/weekly deliverables by the agreed deadlines.

Do Not:

- **Do NOT** share your work computer with family members or allow others to access company systems.
- **Do NOT** work from a public network (café, airport) without activating the Company VPN.
- **Do NOT** record video calls without obtaining prior consent from all participants.

3.4 Data Security and Confidentiality

3.4.1 Confidential Information

All employees must treat the following categories of information as strictly **confidential and proprietary** to DevGuard, and must not disclose, share, copy, or use such information for any purpose outside their employment duties:

- Client data, contracts, project details, pricing, and any personal data of clients or their customers.
- Source code, product designs, algorithms, trade secrets, and any Intellectual Property (IP) developed during employment.
- Business strategies, financial results, M&A; plans, and investor information.
- Internal HR records, salary information, performance data, and employee personal information.
- Vendor agreements, partnership terms, and procurement strategies.

3.4.2 Data Security Rules

- **Passwords:** Passwords must be at least 12 characters long, rotated every 90 days, and never shared.
- **Phishing:** Any suspicious email must be forwarded to security@devguard.com and deleted immediately; do not click links.
- **Data Storage:** Client data must only be stored on Company-approved cloud platforms; personal drives and personal email accounts are prohibited.
- **Printing:** Confidential documents must be shredded immediately after use; do not leave printed confidential documents unattended.
- **Breach Reporting:** Any suspected data breach or unauthorised access must be reported to the IT Security team within **2 hours** of discovery.

3.4.3 Intellectual Property (IP) Ownership

All work product, inventions, developments, and creative works produced by an employee during the course of their employment — whether during or outside of working hours, if related to the Company's business — are the **exclusive intellectual property of DevGuard**. Employees must sign the IP Assignment clause in their employment contract and must not file any patent, copyright, or trademark based on such work without written Company approval.

Violation of the Data Security and Confidentiality policy is treated as Gross Misconduct and may result in immediate termination, civil action for damages, and/or criminal prosecution under applicable information technology and intellectual property laws.

■ CHATBOT QUICK-REFERENCE Q&A

Q: What should I do if I accidentally receive a confidential email not meant for me?

A: Do not forward, print, or act on the email. Immediately notify your manager and the IT Security team at security@devguard.com with the email's subject line. Delete the email from your inbox and trash folder. You must not disclose the contents to any third party.

Q: Am I allowed to use my personal laptop for work if my company laptop is being repaired?

A: No. You must not use a personal device for Company work without a signed BYOD (Bring Your Own Device) Agreement approved by IT and HR. If your company laptop is under repair, contact IT at it.support@devguard.com immediately. IT will arrange a temporary loan device. Work may also be performed from the office during the repair period.

Q: Can I work from a coffee shop or public space?

A: You may work from a public space only if you (a) activate the Company VPN before accessing any company system, (b) ensure your screen is not visible to others when handling confidential data, and (c) do not join client calls with sensitive discussions in a public space. Repeated use of unsecured networks without VPN is a policy violation.

Q: I witnessed a colleague being bullied by a senior. What should I do?

A: You should report the incident through the following channels: (1) Directly inform the HR Business Partner for your department via hrbp@devguard.com, or (2) File an anonymous complaint via the Apex Grievance Portal (available on the intranet). If the bullying involves sexual harassment, you may also file directly with the Internal Committee at ic.chairperson@devguard.com. All complaints are treated with strict confidentiality. Retaliation against anyone who raises a genuine complaint is itself treated as misconduct.

SECTION 4

Resignation, Termination & Exit Procedure

4.1 Voluntary Resignation — Step-by-Step Procedure

An employee who wishes to voluntarily resign from DevGuard must follow the procedure outlined below. Verbal resignations are not accepted and have no legal standing.

Step 1 — Written Resignation

Compose a formal resignation letter addressed to your Immediate Manager with a copy (CC) to the HR Business Partner (hrbp@devguard.com). The letter must clearly state: (a) your full name and employee ID, (b) your designation and department, (c) your intended last working day (calculated as today's date + notice period), and (d) a brief reason for resignation (optional but appreciated).

Step 2 — HRMS Submission

Log into Apex HRM and submit your resignation under Employee Self-Service > Resignation. Attach the signed resignation letter as a PDF. The HRMS submission timestamp constitutes the official resignation date.

Step 3 — Manager Acknowledgement

Your manager must acknowledge the resignation in writing (email or HRMS) within 3 working days. If they do not, HR will send an automatic reminder. Acknowledgement does not imply acceptance of a shorter notice period.

Step 4 — HR Verification

HR will verify your resignation within 2 working days and send you a Resignation Acceptance Letter confirming your last working day, any pending leave balances, and the F&F; Settlement process.

Step 5 — Knowledge Transfer

From the date of resignation acknowledgement, you are required to prepare a detailed Knowledge Transfer (KT) document and train your replacement or designated team member. Failure to complete KT without valid reason may result in withholding of the Experience Letter until KT is certified complete by your manager.

Step 6 — Exit Interview

HR will schedule a 30-minute exit interview within 5 working days of your resignation. The exit interview is confidential and is used solely for Company improvement purposes.

Step 7 — Asset Return & Clearance

On your last working day, complete all asset returns and obtain clearance signatures from IT, Admin, Finance, and HR. (Refer to Section 4.4 for the full asset checklist.)

4.2 Notice Period

During Probation (first 6 months)	30 calendar days
Post-Confirmation — Individual Contributors (all levels)	60 calendar days
Post-Confirmation — Manager / Senior Manager	90 calendar days
Post-Confirmation — Director and Above	90 calendar days
Notice Period Start Date	The calendar day immediately following the HRMS resignation submission date

4.2.1 Notice Buyout (Early Relieving)

An employee may request early relieving before completing the full notice period. Early relieving is subject to **management and HR approval** and is not a right. If approved:

- The employee must pay a **Notice Buyout Amount** equal to the gross daily salary multiplied by the number of notice days waived.
- Notice Buyout payment must be made to DevGuard Finance by the last working day; it will be deducted from the F&F; Settlement if not paid in advance.
- A minimum of **30 days of actual service** must be served post-resignation before early buyout is considered, except in cases of medical emergency (supported by documentation).

4.2.2 Using Leaves to Offset Notice Period

Earned Leave (EL) balance may be adjusted against the notice period only with explicit written approval from the line manager and HR. CL and SL balances **cannot** be used to offset the notice period. Leaves cannot be taken (other than genuine medical emergencies) during the notice period without prior manager approval; unauthorised absence during notice period will extend the last working day by an equivalent number of days.

4.3 Full and Final (F&F;) Settlement

The Full and Final Settlement encompasses all financial dues payable to or recoverable from an employee upon separation from DevGuard.

4.3.1 F&F; Timeline

F&F; Processing Initiation	Within 7 working days of the last working day, provided all clearances are complete
F&F; Payment Disbursement	Within 45 calendar days of the last working day

Delay Liability	If F&F; is not processed within 45 days due to Company delay (not employee-side pending items), the employee is entitled to contact the CHRO for escalation
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4.3.2 Components of F&F;

- **Salary for last working month** (pro-rated to the last working day)
- **Earned Leave (EL) Encashment** — up to 45 days of accumulated EL balance at Basic Salary daily rate
- **Bonus / Variable Pay** (if in the payout window as per the bonus cycle policy)
- **Gratuity** — payable if the employee has completed **5 or more years of continuous service**, calculated as: $(15/26) \times \text{Basic Salary} \times \text{Years of Service}$
- **Provident Fund** — employee's and employer's PF contributions transferred/withdrawn per PF Act
- **Reimbursement of pending expense claims** (submitted and approved before the last working day)

4.3.3 F&F; Deductions

- Outstanding Notice Buyout Amount (if applicable)
- Cost of unreturned/damaged company assets
- Any salary advance outstanding
- Employee's portion of any pending statutory dues

4.3.4 Documents Issued Post-Separation

Experience / Relieving Letter	Issued on the last working day (or within 5 working days if KT is pending certification)
F&F; Statement	Issued within 45 days via registered email
Form 16 (Income Tax)	Issued by July 31 of the financial year of exit
PF Transfer Form	Processed online via EPFO within 30 days of exit; employee receives UAN transfer notification

4.4 Company Asset Return Checklist

All company assets must be returned in good working condition on or before the **last working day**. Damaged or unreturned assets will be valued and deducted from the F&F; Settlement.

Asset	Return Procedure
Company Laptop / Desktop	Full factory reset performed by IT; all data wiped; physical condition inspected by IT
Mobile Phone (if issued)	SIM removed; device restored to factory settings; accessories (charger, case) returned

Access Cards / ID Badge	Returned to Admin / Security desk on last day; non-return: INR 500 deduction
Keys (office, locker, etc.)	Returned to Admin; all keys accounted for
Software Tokens / Dongles	Returned to IT; serial numbers verified
Credit Cards / Petty Cash	Final reconciliation submitted to Finance; cards surrendered
Books / Technical Manuals	Returned to Library/Admin
Printed Confidential Documents	Shredded in presence of HR/IT before last day

4.5 Termination for Cause

DevGuard reserves the right to terminate an employee's services with immediate effect and **without payment in lieu of notice** for any of the following acts of **Gross Misconduct**:

- **Theft, fraud, or dishonesty** involving company or client property.
- **Deliberate data breach** — unauthorised access, theft, or disclosure of confidential company data, source code, or client information.
- **Sexual harassment** — where an inquiry under POSH finds the complaint substantiated.
- **Physical violence or threat of violence** against any colleague, client, or visitor.
- **Falsification of records** — including timesheets, expense claims, educational certificates, or HR documents.
- **Insubordination** — deliberate and repeated refusal to follow lawful and reasonable instructions from management.
- **Serious breach of confidentiality** or non-compete obligations.
- **Being under the influence of alcohol or illegal substances** on company premises or while representing the Company.

4.5.1 Disciplinary Procedure for Lesser Misconduct

For misconduct that does not constitute gross misconduct, the following progressive disciplinary procedure applies:

- Stage 1: **Verbal Warning** — issued by line manager, documented in HR system.
- Stage 2: **Written Warning (Level 1)** — issued by HR after manager's escalation; placed in employee's permanent file.
- Stage 3: **Written Warning (Level 2 / Final Warning)** — issued by CHRO or HR Head; employee has 5 working days to respond in writing.
- Stage 4: **Suspension (with pay)** — pending inquiry, if the nature of misconduct requires investigation.
- Stage 5: **Termination** — after due inquiry, show-cause notice, and management decision.

The right to natural justice is maintained throughout all disciplinary proceedings. Employees have the right to present their case and be heard before any final disciplinary action is taken. An employee may not be dismissed based solely on the accusation of a third party without an independent inquiry.

■ CHATBOT QUICK-REFERENCE Q&A

Q: What is the exact procedure if I want to leave the company?

A: Step 1: Submit a formal written resignation letter to your manager via email (CC: hrhp@devguard.com). Step 2: Log in to Apex HRM > Employee Self-Service > Resignation and submit the same letter. Step 3: Your manager must acknowledge in writing within 3 working days. Step 4: HR will issue a Resignation Acceptance Letter confirming your last working day. Step 5: Serve your full notice period (30, 60, or 90 days depending on your level). Step 6: Complete Knowledge Transfer and get KT sign-off from your manager. Step 7: Return all company assets on your last day and collect clearances. Step 8: HR will process your F&F; Settlement within 45 days of your last working day.

Q: Can I shorten my notice period using my remaining Earned Leave balance?

A: Yes, but only with explicit written approval from both your line manager and HR. You may apply your Earned Leave (EL) balance to offset notice days. For example, if your notice period is 60 days and you have 10 EL days approved for offset, your actual last working day moves 10 days earlier. Note: CL and SL balances cannot be used to offset the notice period. If your EL offset request is not approved, you must either serve the full notice period or pay a Notice Buyout Amount.

Q: When will I receive my relieving letter and F&F; payment?

A: Your Experience/Relieving Letter will be issued on your last working day (or within 5 working days if Knowledge Transfer certification is still pending). Your Full and Final (F&F;) Settlement payment will be processed within 45 calendar days of your last working day, provided all asset clearances have been completed and no financial dues are outstanding.

Q: What happens if I do not return my company laptop before leaving?

A: If you fail to return company assets, their current market value (as assessed by IT) will be deducted from your F&F; Settlement. If the deduction exceeds your F&F; dues, DevGuard may pursue recovery through legal channels. Additionally, your Experience Letter will be withheld until asset dues are cleared.

Q: Can I be terminated without a warning?

A: Yes, in cases of Gross Misconduct (as listed in Section 4.5), DevGuard may terminate your employment immediately without notice and without payment in lieu of notice. For all other forms of misconduct, a progressive disciplinary procedure (verbal warning → written warnings → termination) is followed, and you will have the opportunity to present your case before any final decision is made.

Q: Am I eligible for gratuity when I resign?

A: Yes, provided you have completed at least 5 continuous years of service with DevGuard. Gratuity is calculated as: $(15 \div 26) \times \text{your last drawn Basic Salary} \times \text{number of completed years of service}$. It is paid as part of your F&F; Settlement. If you have served less than 5 years, you are not entitled to gratuity under the Payment of Gratuity Act, 1972.

SECTION 5

Benefits, Compensation & Grievance

5.1 Compensation Structure

DevGuard follows a **Total Rewards philosophy**, ensuring employees are compensated fairly, competitively, and transparently. The compensation package comprises the following components:

Basic Salary	40–50% of CTC; forms the basis for PF, gratuity, and leave encashment calculations
HRA (House Rent Allowance)	50% of Basic Salary for metro cities; 40% for non-metro cities
Special Allowance	Flexible component making up the remainder of the gross salary
Variable Pay	5–20% of CTC depending on grade; disbursed annually upon performance review completion
Provident Fund (PF)	12% of Basic Salary contributed by employee; 12% matched by employer; deposited monthly to EPFO
Professional Tax	Deducted per applicable state slab
Payslip	Generated on the 1st of each month for the preceding month; accessible via Apex HRM > Payroll
Salary Credit Date	Salary is credited on or before the last working day of each month

5.2 Performance Appraisal

5.2.1 Appraisal Cycle

Appraisal Frequency	Annual (April 1 – March 31 performance year)
Appraisal Window	Self-appraisal submissions: April 1–15 ; Manager reviews: April 16–30; HR moderation: May 1–15; Outcome communication: by May 31

Mid-Year Check-In	October — informal 1:1 mid-year review (not linked to increment)
Rating Scale	5-point scale: 5 = Exceptional, 4 = Exceeds Expectations, 3 = Meets Expectations, 2 = Needs Improvement, 1 = Unsatisfactory
Performance Improvement Plan (PIP)	Employees rated 1 or 2 for two consecutive quarters will be placed on a formal 90-day PIP with measurable targets

5.2.2 Increment Policy

Increment Effective Date	July 1 of each year
Increment Range	0–25% of current CTC based on performance rating, market benchmarking, and business performance
Rating 5 (Exceptional)	15–25% increment + eligible for fast-track promotion consideration
Rating 4 (Exceeds Expectations)	10–15% increment
Rating 3 (Meets Expectations)	5–10% increment
Rating 2 (Needs Improvement)	0–3% increment (no guaranteed increment)
Rating 1 (Unsatisfactory)	No increment; PIP initiated
Probation Employees	Not eligible for the annual appraisal cycle; reviewed separately at confirmation

5.2.3 Promotion Criteria

- Minimum **2 consecutive years** in the current role with a rating of 4 or above in the most recent appraisal.
- Availability of a budgeted position at the target grade.
- Recommendation by the line manager and approval by the Department Head and CHRO.
- No active disciplinary action at the time of promotion consideration.
- Successful demonstration of competencies mapped to the target role (assessed through a Competency Interview for Band 5 and above).

5.3 Health Insurance & Wellness Benefits

Group Medical Insurance	DevGuard provides cashless group health insurance for all confirmed employees and their dependants
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Coverage — Employee	INR 5,00,000 per annum (Sum Insured)
Coverage — Family	Spouse + up to 2 dependent children covered under the base policy at no additional premium
Parents / In-Laws	Optional top-up for parents/in-laws available at a subsidised group rate; premium shared 50:50 between employee and Company
Pre-Existing Conditions	Covered from Day 1 of policy activation (no waiting period under the group policy)
Cashless Network	Access to 10,000+ network hospitals; list available on the insurer's app and Apex HRM
Reimbursement	Non-network hospital claims reimbursed within 30 days of submitting documents to HR
Policy Activation	Insurance is activated on the date of confirmation (post-probation); probationers are eligible for personal accident coverage only
Annual Health Check-Up	Once per year — Company-sponsored full-body health check-up at partnered diagnostic centres for all confirmed employees

5.3.1 Mental Health & Wellness

Employee Assistance Programme (EAP)	All employees have access to 6 free, confidential counselling sessions per year with a licensed psychologist via the EAP partner; contact eap@devguard.com
Mental Health Days	2 dedicated Mental Health Days per year (separate from SL); no medical certificate required; apply via Apex HRM as 'Mental Health Leave'
Wellness Stipend	INR 3,000 per quarter reimbursable for gym memberships, fitness apps, yoga classes, or mental wellness apps; claim via Apex HRM > Reimbursements > Wellness

5.4 Additional Benefits

Learning & Development (L&D;) Budget	INR 15,000 per employee per year for approved professional courses, certifications, or conferences; approval by manager required; unused amount lapses
Referral Bonus	INR 10,000 – INR 50,000 depending on the level of the referred candidate hired; paid after the referred employee completes 6 months of service
Meal Allowance	INR 2,200 per month tax-exempt meal allowance via meal card for all employees in office locations
Commute Support	Subsidised shuttle service available from designated pick-up points in Bengaluru, Hyderabad, and Pune; 50% cost borne by Company
Long Service Awards	5 years: certificate + INR 10,000 gift voucher; 10 years: plaque + INR 25,000 + additional 5 EL days; 15+ years: trophy + INR 50,000 + 1-week vacation package
Sabbatical Leave	Employees with 7+ years of service may apply for an unpaid sabbatical of 1–3 months ; subject to CHRO approval; one-time per employment tenure

5.5 Grievance Redressal Procedure

DevGuard is committed to providing a fair, confidential, and time-bound mechanism for employees to raise workplace grievances. A grievance is any genuine concern or dissatisfaction relating to working conditions, management decisions, policy application, or interpersonal conflict — **excluding matters already covered under the POSH policy**.

5.5.1 Four-Stage Grievance Process

Stage 1 — Informal Resolution (Days 1–5)

The employee first attempts to resolve the matter directly with the person concerned or through an informal conversation with their immediate manager. Many grievances can be resolved quickly at this stage. If unresolved within 5 working days, proceed to Stage 2.

Stage 2 — HR Business Partner (Days 6–15)

The employee submits a written grievance to the HR Business Partner (hrbp@devguard.com) detailing the nature of the concern, dates of incidents, and desired resolution. The HRBP will acknowledge receipt within **2 working days** and attempt to mediate a resolution within **10 working days** through meetings with both parties.

Stage 3 — HR Head / CHRO (Days 16–30)

If the HRBP's resolution is unsatisfactory, the employee may escalate in writing to the HR Head or CHRO within **5 working days** of the Stage 2 outcome. The CHRO will review the matter independently and issue a final written decision within **15 working days**.

Stage 4 — External Conciliation / Legal

If the employee believes the CHRO's decision is unlawful or violates statutory rights, they may seek external redressal through the appropriate labour authority or court of jurisdiction. DevGuard will cooperate fully with any lawful external inquiry.

5.5.2 Grievance Guidelines

- All grievances must be raised in **good faith**. Vexatious or malicious complaints are subject to disciplinary action.
- An employee may be accompanied by a colleague (not a legal representative) during any Stage 2 or Stage 3 meeting.
- No adverse action, demotion, or retaliation will be taken against an employee for raising a legitimate grievance. Any retaliation is itself treated as Gross Misconduct.
- All grievance records are stored securely in HR files and are accessible only to the HR team, the CHRO, and legal counsel.

■ CHATBOT QUICK-REFERENCE Q&A

Q: When am I eligible for the annual performance appraisal?

A: You are eligible for the annual appraisal if you were confirmed (completed probation) by October 1 of the performance year. If you joined after October 1, your first appraisal will be in the following cycle. Probationers are assessed at the end of probation by their line manager and are not part of the company-wide annual appraisal cycle.

Q: How is my variable pay (bonus) calculated?

A: Variable pay is calculated based on two factors: (1) your personal performance rating from the annual appraisal, and (2) the company's overall business performance for the financial year. The target variable pay percentage is defined in your offer letter (typically 5–20% of CTC). If the company achieves 100% of its targets and you receive a rating of 4 or above, you will receive 100% of your target variable. Payouts are made annually in June or July, post-appraisal completion.

Q: How do I add my spouse and children to the company health insurance?

A: Log in to Apex HRM > Benefits > Health Insurance > Update Dependents. Add your spouse's and children's details along with required documents (marriage certificate, birth certificates). This must be done within 30 days of joining or within 30 days of a life event (marriage, birth). After 30 days, additions are only permitted during the annual open enrollment window in April.

Q: How do I raise a formal grievance against my manager?

A: Step 1: Try to resolve the matter informally with your manager directly (Stage 1). Step 2: If unresolved within 5 working days, email your written grievance to hrbp@devguard.com. Include specific dates, incidents, and the resolution you seek. The HRBP will acknowledge within 2 working days. Step 3: If unsatisfied with the HRBP's outcome, escalate to the CHRO within 5 working days. Your identity and complaint details are confidential throughout the process. You will not face any retaliation for raising a legitimate grievance.

Q: What is the L&D; (Learning & Development) budget and how do I claim it?

A: Every confirmed employee has an annual L&D; budget of INR 15,000 for approved professional development. To claim: (1) Get your manager's written approval for the course/certification before enrolling. (2) After completing the course, submit the receipt and completion certificate via Apex HRM > Reimbursements > L&D; Claim. Approved claims are reimbursed in the next salary cycle. Note: The budget must be used within the financial year (April–March) and cannot be carried forward.

Q: I disagree with my appraisal rating. What can I do?

A: You have the right to request a rating review. Within 5 working days of receiving your appraisal outcome, submit a written objection to your manager detailing specific examples and evidence that support a higher rating. The manager must respond within 5 working days. If still dissatisfied, escalate to the HR Business Partner within 3 working days. The HRBP will conduct a moderation review with the manager and Department Head. The final moderated rating is binding. Note: Ratings of 3 or above are not automatically eligible for upward revision without evidence of significant under-recognition.

EMPLOYEE ACKNOWLEDGEMENT OF RECEIPT

I, the undersigned, acknowledge that I have received, read, and understood the DevGuard Employee Handbook and HR Policy Document (Version 3.0, effective June 1, 2025). I agree to comply with all policies contained herein and understand that this Handbook forms part of my employment agreement with DevGuard.

Employee Full Name:	
Employee ID:	
Designation / Department:	
Date of Joining:	
Date of Acknowledgement:	
Signature:	

Please sign and return this page to HR (hrbp@devguard.com) within 5 working days of joining. Retain a copy for your records. For queries about any policy in this Handbook, contact hrbp@devguard.com or use the Apex HRM Help Desk portal.

DevGuard HR Department · hrbp@devguard.com · ic.chairperson@devguard.com (POSH) · security@devguard.com (Data Security)

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